Learning on an Empty Stomach

Investigating the impacts of school feeding programmes on slum communities in Uganda

Summary - With one of the highest urbanisation rates in the world[1], the population of Uganda's slums are extremely likely to increase in the near future. This, coupled with growing fears over climate change and food security, is likely to exacerbate many existing struggles slum inhabitants face relating to health, nutrition and education. One intervention which aims to target these issues are **school feeding programmes** (SFPs) which are becoming more popular in both the developed and developing world. It was found that these programmes can provide particularly strong benefits in slum communities, yet eradicating these struggles entirely requires a more holistic approach.

Key Findings

- SFPs have great potential to benefit slum communities due to high population density which allows for increased effectiveness of interventions, otherwise known as 'neighbourhood effects'.
- Benefits are more strongly realised in younger children and those who attend regularly.
- SFPs act as a safety net for vulnerable families and help to prevent children from engaging in damaging behaviours at a young age, such as alcohol, drug abuse or even sexual activities.
- There are a number of barriers in achieveing greater success, most notably the issue of limited resources and a potential inability to sustain long-term benefits in older children.
- SFPs target the symptom rather than the source of poverty and therefore the ultimate goal should focus on the development of the country as a whole.

Background to the Issues

Currently, 54% of Uganda's population live in slums[2] which are among the most deprived in the world, lacking adequate infrastructure, sanitation or access to healthcare and education. One of the most pressing issues for these communities is that of **food insecurity**. Food security is where 'all people, at all times, have physical and economic access to sufficient, safe and nutritious food that meets their dietary needs and food preferences for an active and healthy life[3]'. Therefore, food insecurity occurs when there is an absence of this. School feeding programmes (SFPs) aim to address some of these issues and are explicitly advocated in the **Sustainable Development Goals** (SDGs) as being an appropriate strategy to achieve Goal 1: End poverty in all its forms everywhere[4]. SFPs aim to enhance concentration, increase attendance and improve nutritional status by providing school children with a meal or snack during the day. Studies which investigate the impacts of these programmes in urban slum communities are lacking, yet could potentially provide an ideal setting for further expansion of such programmes in the future.

Research Design and Methodology

The findings presented in this policy brief are based on a 6 week research project carried out in Uganda in partnership with Kids Club Kampala (KCK). 7 key informant interviews and 58 household interviews took place across Katanga, Kivulu and Namuwongo in order to assess the impacts of SFPs on these communities. The following findings are not statistically significant and cannot be generalised across the whole population.

Fig. 1 - Food being served in Namuwongo[5]

Findings

Impacts - Impacts of the programme span across many factors, including children's physical appearance, behaviour, families assets, resources and mental wellbeing. **85%** of parents claimed to notice an increase in their children's weight since taking part in the programme, and a further **91%** claim that their children are better behaved now. Parents who are employed cite they now have more time to work and earn much needed income to support their family whilst being content in knowing their children are somewhere safe during the day. For those who are unemployed, the programme offers a safety net and ensures that their children still receive the daily food and education they need. SFPs in slum communities can also help to prevent and reduce the occurrence of damaging behaviours through educating children on the dangers of alcohol, drugs and sexual activities. Such behaviours commonly occur at very young ages in slum environments and can lead to a lifetime of negative consequences, so mitigating this is an extremely positive aspect of the programme.

Barriers - Despite a number of positive impacts, there are a few apparent limitations of this programme which are likely to be common across similar contexts. Firstly, limited resources pose a threat to expanding or even maintaining existing benefits. Being limited to a single classroom easily

***"Without Kids Club, life would be too tough"* - a young mother from Namuwongo**

leads to overcrowding which does not support an effective learning environment. Similarly, as more children attend, portion sizes are reduced in order to spread over a larger number, but this is likely to diminish the physical and nutritional gains for these children. These issues are perhaps more apparent for older children who are largely outnumbered in the classroom and fail to receive larger, targeted portion sizes compared to much younger participants. In addition, children in slums have to mature a lot younger than most and therefore, they may begin engaging in income generating activities at a younger age and are unable to continue attending the programme. Lastly, serving the food at the end of the day in this programme is somewhat untypical of many other SFPs, which serve food either at breakfast or lunch in order to benefit children's cognitive function during lessons[6]. Serving food later allows more children who attend formal schooling to receive food, but this may be at the detriment to educational attainment.

Fig. 2 - Children taking part in education[5]

Underpinning Factors - One of the key reasons for success witnessed in this study was the use of regular meetings between teachers and parents which aim to educate and guide parents on raising their children under such challenging conditions. However, the spread of information regarding when these occur was extremely inefficient and therefore meant a large proportion (approximately **40%**) of participating families missed out. In addition, the fact that slum communities are so densely populated allows the potential for **'neighbourhood effects'** to increase the impacts of the programme on the community as a whole. Parents claim that their children are less likely to get into trouble or be negatively influenced by their surroundings due to the existence of KCKs programme. It can contribute to creating a much safer community in general as children are kept engaged and have somewhere safe to learn and play during the day. Finally, the inclusion of additional programmes such as carpentry workshops, women's initiatives and teens groups strengthen the benefits witnessed in the programme and targets the wider community as a whole.

Conclusion

Overall, these results imply that SFPs can provide a wealth of benefits in slum communities and have strong potential to be replicated across similar contexts. However, the need for a holistic approach is still very evident and therefore SFPs in these settings can be greatly strengthened through the use of complementary programmes. In addition, factors such as household size, composition, age and attendance rate may also influence the impacts of the programme on individuals. More quantitative research which investigates the nutritional and educational impacts of SFPs on slum communities would be extremely beneficial in strengthening the findings outlined in this study.

Policy Recommendations

1. Resources - In order for benefits to be maintained, resources must increase as the project expands. Otherwise, overcrowded classrooms and reduced food portions will dramatically reduce the effectiveness of the programme.

2. Targeted Portion Sizes - To encourage greater participation and realise stronger benefits in older children, portion sizes should be targeted to satisfy age specific needs.

3. Complementary Programmes - Although these are currently offered, benefits could be further realised through expanding these to support nutritional and health matters in order to strengthen the physical gains realised by the programme.

4. Communication - The effective aspects of the programme are somewhat hindered through ineffective dissemination of information regarding complementary programmes and parents meetings. This could be improved through more advertising and more advanced warnings of meetings.

5. Wider Applications - These findings suggest that slum communities offer an ideal setting for further expansion of SFPs. However, overriding factors such as improper sanitation and general poverty can limit their effectiveness and therefore future programmes must ensure the inclusion of complementary programmes which also address these.

References - [1] CIA. 2015. The World Factbook. [Online] Available at: https://www.cia.gov/library/publications/the-world-factbook/fields/2212.html [Accessed 12/09/2017]. [2] The World Bank. 2014. Population Living in Slums [Online] Available at: https://data.worldbank.org/indicator/EN.POP.SLUM.UR.ZS?end=2009&start=1990&view=map&year=2014 [Accessed 12/09/2017]. [3] World Food Summit 1996, cited in Kimani-Murage, E.W., Schofield, L., Wekesah, F., Mohamed, S., Mberu, B., Ettarh, R., Egondi, T., Kyobutungi, C. and Ezeh, A., 2014. Vulnerability to food insecurity in urban slums: experiences from Nairobi, Kenya. *Journal of Urban Health*, 91(6), pp.1098-1113. [4] United Nations (UN) 2015. Sustainable Development Goals [Online] Available at: http://www.un.org/sustainabledevelopment/sustainable-development-goals/ [Accessed 08/08/2017]. [5] Sourced from KCK archives. [6] Kristjansson, E., Robinson, V., Petticrew, M., MacGowan, J., Farmer, A., and Shea, B. 2006. School feeding for improving the physical and psychosocial health of disadvantaged elementary school children. *Cochrane database of systematic reviews*, (1).